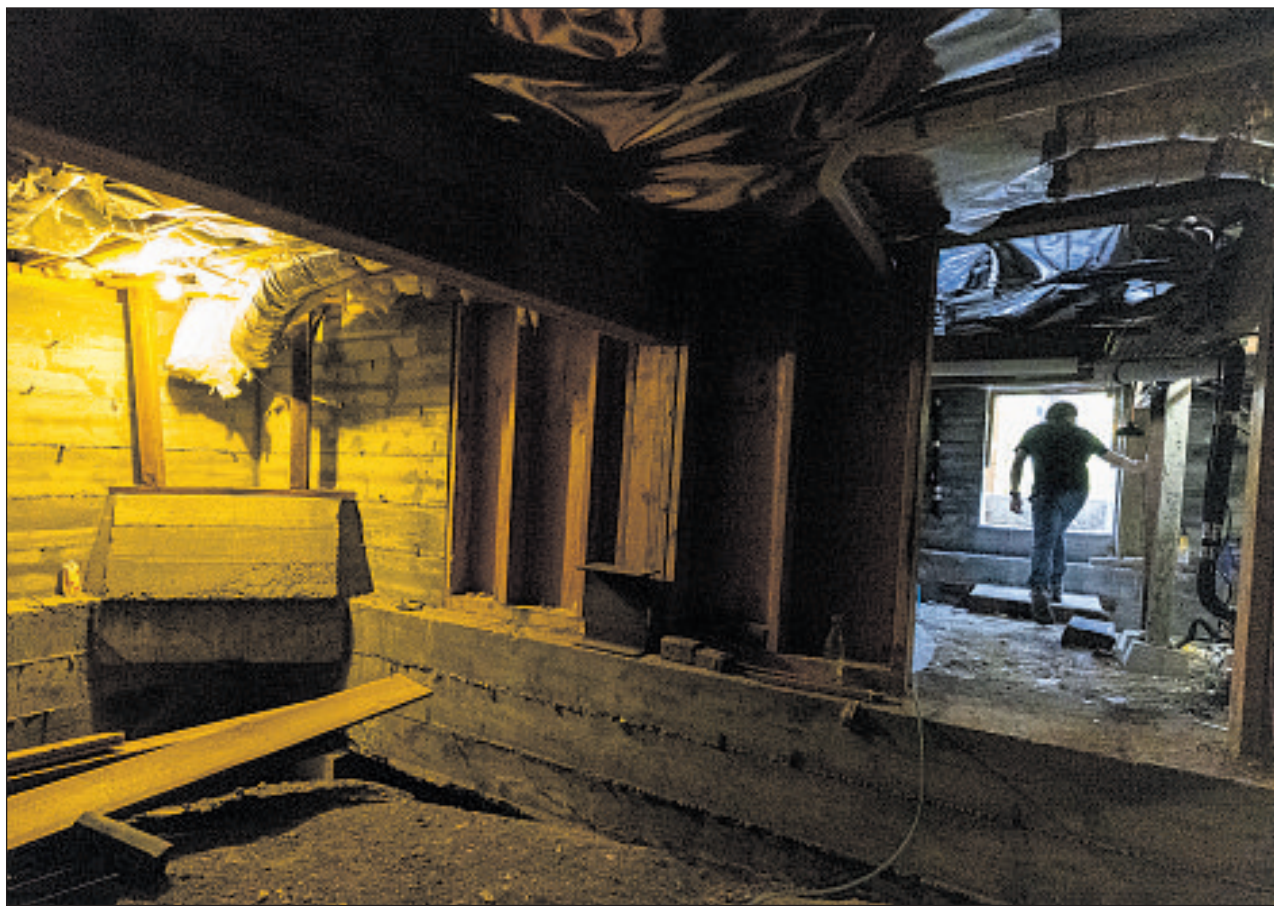




ALLEN J. SCHABEN Los Angeles Times

JOE BADAME checks on recent improvements to his home's foundation in the Portuguese Bend community.

Living off-grid is a new normal for L.A. suburb with ocean views

Rancho Palos Verdes residents in a landslide zone make do after utilities cut service.

By GRACE TOOHEY

Joe Badame and his wife try to reserve laundry for sunny days. They stagger their appliance use in the mornings, checking that a fan isn't running at the same time as the coffeemaker. At night,

Badame obsessively turns off lights. They both keep a constant eye on the app tracking their solar power capacity: Badame's 91-year-old mother-in-law relies on an oxygen machine. "We're very careful, we keep everything off," Badame, 65, said. "As long as it's sunny ... it typically gets us through the night." If their two 13.5-kilowatt batteries, charged by rooftop panels, begin to drop near 20% capacity, they trek down a gravel path to the corner of their front yard

and switch on a massive generator. The whole process has become the new normal for them and most of their neighbors, since public utility companies cut service to much of Rancho Palos Verdes' landslide zone more than a year ago, after months of unprecedented earth movement — making the Portuguese Bend neighborhood one of the state's largest and likeliest off-grid communities. "We've got 100-plus homes in here that are act-

ing like we're out in the middle of the Mojave Desert," said Kent Attridge, president of the Portuguese Bend Community Assn. "We're doing what we have to do to stay in our homes." That's been the overwhelming motivation for residents in this neighborhood, who have refused to relent against an erratic landslide that has presented challenge after challenge. First it was widespread damage from accelerating land movement in early [See Off-grid, A10]

A few bits of plastic are deadly for sea life

By SUSANNE RUST

Ocean plastic kills sea creatures. It can obstruct, perforate or twist their airways and gastrointestinal tracts. Now new research shows it takes just six pieces of ingested rubber the size of a pencil eraser to kill most seabirds. For marine mammals, 29 pieces of any kind of plastic — hard, soft, rubber or fishing equipment — are often lethal. It's the first time researchers have quantified how much and what kind of plastic — soft, hard, rubber or fishing debris — is needed to kill a bird, marine mammal or a turtle. "Seeing the particularly small thresholds for rubber and seabirds, for example, that just six pieces of rubber, each smaller on average than the size of a pea was enough to kill 90% of seabirds that ingested it. ... That was particularly surprising to me," said Erin Murphy, a researcher with the group Ocean Conservancy and the department of ecology and evolution at the University of Toronto. The seabirds were less sensitive to hard plastic: It would take 25 pieces of the pea-sized hard plastic pieces to ensure a 90% chance of dying. Murphy and her colleagues from the University of Tasmania in Australia, the Commonwealth Scientific and Industrial Research Organization, also from Australia, and the Federal University of Alagoas in Brazil published their study last week in the journal Proceedings of the National Academies of Science. For decades, researchers have been documenting death by plastic in marine animals. They have reported [See Plastic, A8]

A Palestinian symbol of resistance — and ruin

By Nabih Bulos

JENIN, West Bank — After 15 months in an Israeli jail, Mustafa Sheta drove home with his brothers to Jenin. A lot changed while he was in prison, they said. The fighters who once had daily run-and-gun battles with Israeli soldiers? Gone. The bustling population of the refugee camp that gave Jenin its reputation as the martyrs' capital? Gone. The theater Sheta ran in the camp, which he nurtured into an internationally known lodestar of Palestinian cultural resistance? Gone. It appeared that Jenin, known as the

city that never surrendered, had surrendered. "I was shocked. The concept of resilience in Jenin, it's really important to people. Where are the fighters, the Palestinian Authority, grassroots organization, the local leaders?" Sheta said. "It felt like we lost the war, like we are losing this battle." Jenin has become the quintessential model of how Israel — in a long-running campaign dubbed Operation Iron Wall — has largely subdued the northern West Bank. [See Jenin, A3]



JOHN WESSELS AFP/Getty Images

ISRAEL'S military campaign has laid waste to the Jenin refugee camp.

Behind a son's smile, a silent untreated crisis

Few screening tools to prevent suicide are tailored to meet needs of autistic youths.

By CORINNE PURTILL

When Anthony Tricarico was diagnosed at 7 with autism spectrum disorder, his parents, Neal and Samara, were told that he might need extra support at school, so they made sure he got it. When doctors suggested therapies for his speech and motor skills, they sought those out too. But when their kind, popular, accomplished boy began to experience depression and suicidal ideation as a teenager, no one told them that the same thinking patterns that powered many of Anthony's achievements might also be amplifying his most harmful thoughts, or that the effort of masking his autism could be hurting his mental health. None of the people or organizations they contacted for help said Anthony might benefit from therapies or safety plans adapted for autistic people, or even that such things existed. They did not say that he might not show the same warning signs as a non-autistic teenager.

And only after he died from suicide in May 2024 did the San Diego County couple discover that autistic kids — particularly those like Anthony, whose disability is not immediately apparent from the outside — are more likely to think about and die from suicide, and at earlier ages, than their neurotypical peers. "Our son has always been different. So why wouldn't how we approach suicide be different?" Neal said. Suicide is a leading cause of death in the U.S. for kids aged 10 to 18. Prevention strategies that take neurodiversity into account could go a long way toward reducing the number of young lives lost. Autism researchers and advocates are working to develop better screening tools and interventions based on the unique strengths and differences of an autistic brain. A crucial first step is educating the people best positioned to help kids when they're in crisis, like parents, counselors, pediatricians and social workers. "These are kids that are experiencing all sorts of heightened risk," said Danielle Roubinov, an associate professor and director of the Child and Adolescent Anxiety and Mood Disorders Program at University of North [See Anthony, A6]



GENARO MOLINA Los Angeles Times

A PAINTED rock is one of many in a memorial for Anthony Tricarico, a popular, accomplished teen.

Seeking answers in their child's death

Parents hired their own investigators in a case that has divided L.A. law enforcement.

By LIBOR JANY

When Amelia Salehpour walked away from an Orange County drug treatment facility, her parents turned to the police for help. She was in danger — they were sure of it. The 18-year-old checked herself out of Saddleback Recovery in Costa Mesa on a summer day in 2023 and hopped into a car with her ex-boyfriend and a man he called "Raider." Together, they drove up to the San Fernando Valley. After tracking his daughter down to what a prosecutor later called a "house of horrors" in Van Nuys, Ali Salehpour decided to call 911.

Amelia, he said, struggled with mental illness and had the cognitive abilities of an eighth-grader, which made her vulnerable to manipulation. Her family pleaded for officers to come check on her. The first cops arrived hours later. They knocked on a side gate and left after getting no response. The next day, after more prodding by Amelia's father, police received permission to search some parts of the house but found no sign of her. Then, less than 24 hours later, someone inside the house called police to report a death. Officers found Amelia in a garage, next to syringes and a burned spoon with a sticky black substance. The first LAPD investigators on scene ruled it an open-and-shut case of accidental overdose. The medical examiner's office agreed. [See Daughter, A9]

Saying POW! to city's ban on comics

By SOPHIE AUSTIN

SACRAMENTO — On a recent day at Sacramento native Lecho Lopez's comic shop in the city, his 5-year-old nephew read his first word aloud: "bad." It was from a graphic novel. There was irony in that being his first word, because Lopez credits comic books with many positive things in his life. That is why he supports repealing a city ordinance

dating to 1949 that bars the distribution of many comic books to kids and teens. It is not enforced today. "It's a silly law," said Lopez, who has a red-and-black tattoo of the Superman logo on his forearm, in an interview at his store, JLA Comics. "A lot of good things come out of comic books." A City Council committee unanimously voted last week to advance the repeal

and designate the third week of September as "Sacramento Comic Book Week." It now heads to the full council for a vote. The ban prohibits distributing comic books prominently featuring an account of crime that show images of illegal acts such as arson, murder or rape to anyone under 18. In the mid-20th century, as comic books were on the rise, fears spread over their effect on children, with some [See Comics, A8]

Progress cited on end to Ukraine war

Top U.S. and Ukrainian officials provide scant details about a peace proposal with Russia. **WORLD, A2**

Seized in raid, man has vanished

Six weeks after an L.A. immigration sweep, feds and family find no trace of him. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Weather

Mostly sunny. L.A. Basin: 68/52. **B5**

Business **A11**
Opinion Voices **A13**

A 'Saving Grace' for Robert Plant

The Led Zeppelin singer shape-shifts yet again on his latest solo album. **ENTERTAINMENT, E1**

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